great opening!

We were told it would be neon soaked and dystopic but it wasn't. We ended up with a lot of leisure time. Finding the flesh-embedded implants gross, we moved away from that quickly I'd say - the ones who got it first because it was cool now are filing some class action lawsuit. What they want isn't particularly clear because they won't get money for it - that's for sure. BIPS run the world and as of two days ago my bank looked healthy. Hey, it's living. So then… let's see now… right, if you have any taste at all you got the subtle implants. Everyone's a genius now, at least by 204x standards. My balls still sweat, still stick to the inside of my leg, and I like it that way. I like the tack - tactile. Let me get up. Wait. Not yet.

watch tense shifts

I roll around in bed, ah, that luxurious feeling, aren't we so glad that agriculture found us and we passed through feudalism, communism, early capitalism - granted, it was sketchy for a while. My folks never stopped reminding me of it; that's stayed the same, the old people like to gripe. I can't wait to get old so I can grumble the same way - I think it would be so satisfying, the same way complaining on a hike is. Ok. That's not me, that's a friend, but I get it. Satisfying like peeling a testicle; Yes, thank god, those are still real.

Well, you're probably curious about my day. You'd say, "what does a man living in 209x do all day?" And I'd look at your <209x neanderthal ass with disdain. Do? What do you mean, do? I do whatever I want, which for the most part, was nothing. "You ought to get a job," says the man poor in jobs starting with blow-, hand-, and tit- (one of my favorites). What Eveline can do with her body would absolutely drive a man insane, insane(!) from 204x. I say the 204x a lot because, eh, we kind of had a war there. I was born just right around then and don't really know because my records along with the

rest of everybody's got wiped clean. But that's unimportant. What is important is that I'm safe, my family's safe, health is wealth, and that's more true than of any other time in history. The longer you live, you more time you get to spend with [friends | family | lovers | money]. Money. I got to you about New Money. Can you take a deep breath for me and just appreciate the beauty of your moment? You found my journal which means we both made it. Hooray! And I'll take care of you - I love taking care of people - and before you put your guard up with that unreliable narrator bollock, know that my reliability score is a perfect 10. Out of 12. That's just my last three lovers and we don't talk about the ones before. It's really the unreliable age and I'm the man for this age. Except to Eve; but I'll get to her.

Where was I, right, schedule. Well I'll let you in on a secret because we're friends and I'll let you in on my real schedule. Even presenting you with this unabashed admission is a real thrust of friendship, you know. According to my public schedule, I rise early. An early riser, I'm up at 6. No, 5. It's been a while since I've seen it. I meditate, I get myself prepared for the day; My morning is a gauntlet I tell you; I barely make it out of my room I tell you - I could have died from the training in there. When I exit, it is with bloodied fingers gripped around the doorframe as I pull myself through the egress, and if you were to see me, you'd think (if you had any idea at all) "That's a man, he fights his way out of the pit every morning, how could I not have known that. To wake up is a life-or-death manuever and for him, he's a fighter. He's like that Overman from Zarathustra, there is no meaning in this world but he wroughts it with his Rodinesque hands made of pure iron and he seizes the day from the clutch of the meanderous night and he makes something out of it, he makes an image out of his illusory self."

I'm assuming this is metaphorical and not literal

one classical comp per moment

good

It's almost ten to twelve and I ought to get up now. ha

So, why are you reading this? I mean, why am I writing this? Because if you're reading this it means a self fulfilling prophesy has occurred and this work has survived some catastrophe, has some merit. Because out of all the intra- and intro-tainments at your disposal, you picked up this one. I congratulate the both of us. My therapist urges me to write it down because it'll do me good, so I have, by hand, because you know what, I'm sick like that and with all the wonderful time I have, I rather enjoy it when the ink bleeds into the page and the pen nib knicks into the soft belly of the stack. But I digress - I tend to do that a lot.

So, it is a particularly good world except everyone's a therapist. My cousin said he'd be my therapist and I told him I'd be caught dead to rights seen talking to him. He's got a competence score of 2 out of 12. We've really got a continued fixation as a society with this dozen thing and as a numeral base it makes no sense; And there's a number called the Baker's Dozen which is 13? Just call it *numero Cristo* like any normal person. Yes, I'm Christian, and no, I'm not alone. It's really *a la carte* now. My friend is a good techno-Islamist with a neo-Catholic bent, which means he lives his life for Allah and thinks technology is the best way to offer prayer to the Almighty, and he really, *really* likes going to mass on Sundays to look at Catholic girls. Honestly, which red-blooded male does not? When nudism is passe coverage is revealing, and those girls really know how to cover themselves well. Right, and I got a friend who's a purist Tekite. He's dull but he's got a full competence score so we like having him around in case. "Ander, baby," Cathay said to me, "you're the best Christian to have around, you never question God." And I keep going down. I think they like having me around because I'm devoted.

If you look at my scores, you'd think, that's an underachiever. But if you'd see me in person, then you'd *know* I was underachieving. I never get out of bed unless I have to. It's 12 now and I have brunch at 1.

And yes, it is still 209x the year of our Lord. If you say common era, that's just norm brained I'd never want to be within 2 social degrees of you. Your 1st degree friends would be along the bump with you and 2nd degree are at most 1-sig. That practically makes you handicapped; Of course you'd be a genius to 204x'ers but really maybe they're not intelligible at all. Why am I writing this. I have one friend who's 3-sig and she's a rockstar. It's true that you can't buy taste no matter how much gear you're on. It works better when you're already smart.

So, a few things did not come to pass. Fully sentient machines, nada. Consciousness to consciousness transfer, instant lobotomy. I'll get to that because this story is mostly about that, but aren't we glad we got proliferation figured out in 204x. Robots are our butlers now. San Francisco is a gorgeous city you know. It's too bad there's a hole where Oakland used to be after the bomb, but look, on the brightside - and I have been told my optimism is part of my charm - the canyon is now the foremost park on the West Coast and it's actually full of oaks now. That's grime so don't think about it too much. On this day too, in particular. The air is so crisp that when I breath in I can smell my IQ rising by 5 points. It really hits you hard in the nostril and burns up the nasal canal to your lizard brain. "Get me out of bed, Eveline," I say.

Shower. What is this breakfast? Pancakes and two eggs. I'm simultaneous insatiable and not hungry. You'd think my breakfast matches my nutritional profile or whatever, but then I'd have to eat like an animal fed from a trough. As long as you stay

consistent with your neural victuals - appetite, nutrition - everything takes care of itself. Sometimes my body just moves on its own and I'm along for the ride. "Ander, baby," Cathay tells me, "you're such a dashing homunculus." I had been advised by my doctor (yes, a human, but don't be too impressed because it's the third most common para-profession after 1) therapist, 2) artist) that I ought to chew because our mandible wasn't evolved to just drink slosh and booze. I contest that fact, but since growing new teeth and shaving the jawline are such painful procedurances [procedure + endurance], I bark on jerky now and then. It's just not becoming. The view is beautiful. Ocean to the left, glimmering pond water to Angel Island to the front, my floor has one more week at the penthouse rotation. I never get tired of it. And you know what else never gets old? The sight of my bride. I mean my ride.

good

It's two-toned. It's red. It's gray. And it's fast. It seats three, I'm the only man allowed in, and when I get in I'm guaranteed an erection. I look at it and I think, "Ander, there is a god and he lives in beautiful things. And he loves you." I swear, since my BIPS count went into overflow, life's been winning. It's like lucky just drops in my lap and heaven's slot machine is working overtime. What's so special about the car, you say? Well it flies, and other than the fact it looks like sex, there's only 100,000 of them in the 'trops. And that's the entire San Francisco Coastal Metropolitan Area! She roars. That's an additional premium to tune the turbines to sound like that. And here we go. I like to keep the muffle down so I can hear the sound of gushing air; It feels like I'm riding on napalm yet the body feel is not unlike that of a snowboard crushing downhill if the snow was pure powder that day. Beautiful.

good

Look I'm not saying I'm not a brat. In a world of plenty, I just have a little more than most people. They ping me the party list - I find out Eve won't be there at brunch. A sad song flows out of the speakers, for a moment I can resist, knowing it stems from my synes-sense. It feels good to fling with sadness and not admit to it; I feed the yearning. I decide I'm not going to brunch with those people. What will I do? I corkscrew in the air and toss my hair centripedally. I know, I get upright, Marco's probably home. I ring him. "Don't bother me." But he says that all the time. "I'm working." You won't even know I'm there. "How could I not?" Look you're already not working. "Because you're bothering me." What are you working on? "The same thing I'm always working on." We can make some progress today. "No, stop calling." Eve's not at brunch. "Where's she?" In Hong Kong. "Is she seeing someone?" I'll get some bagels, you want everything? "No don't come, I'm not dressed." I'm there.

so much linguistically it's hard to see

Marco must be screaming for company. These cerebral types, you have to understand them and easily. The excess of friendly protuberance makes them feel desired; In his imagination, on his deadthbed, he is surrounded by the who's who of worldshapers none of whom were invited and he passes away slightly annoyed. Marco's 2-sig, not 3-sig as he'd like to think, because his misanthrope keeps him from it. Marco's redeeming quality is he has great taste. I kill the turbines and I drop.

I get 20 seconds of this - almost silence. I'm a glider. The wind whips up and back but all I hear is the quiet that's in the loud. I up the music, the synth-sax and the morning sun screams with all its rays and I'm blinded. The system would never let me crash - I paid an aftermarket mechanic to drop the floor to the city's environmental limit - its Mind will intervene and I get a huge fine but maybe I'm daring for some financial

good

punishment today. I can't think. My mind is sluggish. Feels like I have sludge in the brain pipes. Who am I to say anything about Marco. Maybe he really doesn't want me there. Maybe he really doesn't want me there and he is steadfastly working on the thing that'll never be done and it gives him meaning because when it's done he dies. Maybe not physically, this ego of his will die and he can't let go of it. It's all projection. That's a new trick my therapist (not my idiot incompetant cousin) taught me. Whatever I'm saying of other people, it's most likely that I'm addressing myself. I told her to fuck herself, she looked so sexy, and I was so angry and aroused. But I try it and I feel relief. Maybe it is me. Maybe it is not Marco who doesn't want to see anyone but it's this hypocrite called myself. What do I know what he wants on his deadbed. It would be nice if I was surrounded by people whom I dismiss. Why do I do this, am I not loved or something. I get a sense I ought to deloop. *'This architecture of thought is unproductive for you,'* my therapist says. I take a breath and feel the air sting my nostril. It is quiet up here. I don't see any birds, wait, yes, some in the distance. It's fine, everything's fine, Eve's going to be there in the future, there's more brunches, and I'm not going to crash. I pull up on the throttle and the turbines fire up. I dip, bottom heavy, and 100 meters before I hit the water I blast off and skip across the horizon like a pebble. Marco rings me. "Hey stop skidding out. I'm going to get a fine." Let me land, I say to him. "Did you get the bagels?" he asks.

good

I let go of the controls when I feel a gentle nudge as his property's Mind takes over. The craft rights itself and levels off to the pad on the island. I've missed the angle and Marco's island's Mind takes me up on a high, scenic arc. He got the place for cheap, I thought. Artificial, sure, but it was a big piece of engineered land off the shore

of the bay, and he had it done classic greco style. From this vantage, I see Marco's whole house is one large bandshell. I see his desk on the stage under the half arch. That's the whole house. His studio hides in the back, but he likes to write and recreate on the terraced stage under the staggering half-dome looking out to the water and the city. He has the curtains drawn up now, giant, hundred-pound velvet red curtains. I complete the circle and land on the pad. Marco really wasn't dressed, in slippers and wearing a blanket like a robe. He's paused working but doesn't look to greet me, sitting high on his platform. I get out, run my hands along the curves of the craft while it spins lazily down into the garage. I enjoy the air as I walk to him, the sun is quite gentle today. "So you didn't get the bagels," he says to me when I'm within earshot. I have no idea what he's talking about.

all good

I like getting out of his mind and getting more of the world/ his perception of setting

"Aren't you going to burn here?" I complete the steps to the bandshell. I pull up a chair and sit next to Marco but not behind him with visibility of his work. I don't violate his privacy, that was the courtesy.

"Do you want the shades?" he asks, pointing up. I see the thin layer that would cover the half-arch and make it like a monolith from which, within, we could look out. I shake my head and lean back. I could use some sun, my skin's dithered to a paleness. "How long has it been since you've left your room?" he says. A *whyle*. How's the work coming along, I ask. "Well," he says. I perk up, really? You've never said well. The sun's our third companion and fills in the motes of silence with warmth.

good

You miss her? He says.

I do. This guy, talks so much. I do, I think about her. But Marco, I wonder, do I think about her only because I have nothing else to think about. What do you think

about? Some guitar invades the stage and he dims it down. No, leave it up a bit. The repeating chords gets our brainwaves into a semi-lucid stage where creativity burgeons out. He motions to a pipe, I refrain and he takes a sip. I motion to his mistress, I also ask him if it is alright; she applies lotion to my body and face. I take off my shirt and I lounge under the sun. Marco bends over his desk and obsessed over his work.

Who's going to see it? I ask Marco

He doesn't answer me, and I find that rude. I sit with that feeling a bit, it's like a tight little worm in my heart. I imagine a worm in a bad apple core oxidized brown. It makes its way to my skin and I feel it crawl along the surface. Tanning gives me an awful itch but I'm also so sunlazed that I cannot move. The soft, gentle sun, the pampering breeze, the sustenance like marrow. That itchy feeling goes away. Once I'm off my nerve, Marco replies; He's admiring a passage he'd constructed and he says "I dunno," he cranks his neck and looks at it differently and mentions, "you?"

is this text?
Can we see the device/
embody this a bit more?

That's right. I forget. We've been his audience. Cathay and Ah Ann ping me, "Why did you leave us to this meal \ I thought you were going to be here now we can't leave" "Why not?" I feel her annoyance like a little flame. "Okay I get it sorry," I say. "Where are you?" "I'm at Marco's, want to join us?" Marco shoots me a dirty look then bends over his work.

When Marco straightens up, I know they're calling him. "Hey don't exclude me," I say, but it's already done. I keep one eye open on the conversation, the other I keep closed. I wonder if a single eyelid can be tanned more than the other. It must be able. They weren't upset I ditched them at the brunch; they were upset my motive was ulterior. I'll think of an apology when they arrive - it'll be entertaining. To me, right, I

ought to be a bit less self-centered. I had a dream once that I sneezed on an actor disguised as old Nixon and he said “you would be more successful if you cared about other people more.” It was an underground gala with tunnels as high and wide as ballrooms connected to one another and Eve and I had been chasing each other from cavern to cavern until I caught her in a utility passage and we kissed deeply and longingly. Then she ran into the crowd again. Two pelicans skim over the water and I watch mesmerized.

good

at? in?

I mull over several things to ask Marco but he’s so steeped in his work I feel bad pulling him out. It would be a great violation of our friendship. And I feel his getting into the depth of it, I don’t even dare move a muscle or make a sound, the guitar changes to strings and it rises, I’m catatonic and I see Marco go deeper and deeper until tears emerge. He wipes the beads away and sits dignified; it’s over. He had a moment and I was witness to it. He clacks the pages on the table, aligns them flush - feeling the weight of his afternoon - he shoves the stack away. He closes the pen cap ceremonious too and pushes it next to the paper and folds his arms across his breast looking at the pink pastel sky. The sun had moved from west to further west and is lowering down. The afternoon had been spent and we move toward evening. I had darkened a few degrees. Cathy’s craft, vibrantly red and green like a parrot, lull over the water. They stay in the air to take in the golden hour.

Contemplative questions:

What are your “likability” goals for Bruce? (I assume this is Bruce because of the title, though he refers to himself as Ander)

How does this narrative personality reconcile with what is written about Bruce in the synopsis? Is this pre-some life-changing event?

How does this voice relate to him being a Vulture?

Where do you desire him to be on the reliable/unreliable narrator scale?